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The position of women in a pastoral society

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Document Type: Essay

Original Page: 72

Culture (OWC): [Fulani \(MS11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1951-1955

Coverage Date: 1951 AD - 1951 AD

Place Coverage: Southwestern Niger

Section Title(S)

2. The married woman and her husband's family • 3. The married woman and her children

Thus, deferent towards her husband's parents and her elder brothers, a woman is on equal terms often of an affectionate and friendly nature with her sisters-in-law, and has a joking relationship with her younger brothers-in-law. But she will not have a permanently subordinate position in these surroundings to which her marriage has brought her. Once the first years of adaptation are over, her status as wife and as mother will give her a place in the life of the camp which can become extremely influential.

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3. *The married woman and her children*

The reason why the birth of the first child is awaited with such eagerness is that having a child is what gives a married woman her purpose in life. Some childless women learn with the years to make the best of things by adopting a daughter or two daughters, but not before having tried out all the traditional remedies, consulted the baobab of Dakoro, or even married several husbands in the hope of having a child. A man who has learnt by experience that he is impotent will provide himself with an heir by "surrendering his mat" and his wife to a temporary substitute whose sole function in such a case is a biological one. To her children, the mother is the chief representative of the uterine kin who are related "through the milk" and whose characteristic feelings towards each other are those of devotion and affection. It is she who brings up her sons during their early years and who remains the counsellor of

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her married daughters. She never gives any open signs of her affection for them, because it is not customary in this society to give, overt expression to feelings, and any public exhibition of affection towards her eldest son would be particularly shameful.

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The instability of a wife's position might be thought to be detrimental to her children, for if she leaves her husband she is obliged to let him keep her sons at least. But even so, such children are not entirely cut off from their mother and their mother's family, and later in life mother and sons will come together again. The youngest, son is very often the favourite, and the most devoted to his mother because he is the last to leave the family camp and is there to look after her at the time when she is getting on in years. She in turn surrounds him with affection and showers him with small presents.

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